

Creative Sound Blaster X-Fi

Your Ticket To The Audiophile World

The X-Fi is Creative's latest offering. X-Fi stands for eXtreme Fidelity sound, and this is made possible by the use of a Cirrus Logic 24-bit DAC and an audiophile-grade SNR ratio of 116 db. Its USP is a really fast audio processor with 51 million transistors capable of delivering over 30,000 MIPS of processing speed, making it 24 times more powerful than its predecessor from the Audigy series.

This power is harnessed in Creative's proprietary 24-bit Crystallizer, which essentially up-samples audio to 24-bit/96 kHz to improve sound quality. This is a godsend for MP3, and while we were testing, we found that the card fished out more details from our test MP3 collection than did the Audigy 2 card.

The X-Fi Elite Pro we received for preview was fully-loaded with a well-designed ergonomic remote and an external I/O module, housing every possible interconnect any audiophile would wish for. This is interfaced with the sound card using a special 26-pin cable called the AD link. The components used on the cards are of premium quality, which is evident from the clicking sound that the high grade relays make when changing modes.

The 400 MHz processor along with other processing elements like the DAC, SRC (Sample Rate Converter), filter, mixer, etc., allows a staggering 4,096 audio channels, and up to eight simultaneous real-time effects. This, paired with ASIO (Audio Stream Input/Output), translates into zero processor

overhead for frequency conversion. This is a welcome inclusion, as Creative was facing a lot of flak from audiophiles because the older Audigy line of cards resampled all frequencies by default into 48 kHz. The X-Fi, however, sports true hardware 24-bit 96 kHz audio playback for up to 7.1 discrete channels and 192 kHz for digital stereo playback.

This card is especially a boon for gamers due to the onboard 64 MB X-Ram, which allows an audio buffer for storing uncompressed audio samples reducing quality loss and consequent CPU overhead. Desktop audio professionals, too, have a lot to be thankful for, with 96/24 audio mastering and editing quality, along with 24-bit sound fonts and the 3D Midi feature, with the ability to interface midi devices with the card.

Our verdict: in terms of audio quality, the Creative X-Fi's onboard DAC and Dolby and DTS decoders are capable of providing a high-quality movie experience. The sheer quality, power, and real-time audio editing will appeal to gamers, home theatre enthusiasts and audio professionals alike. Quite simply, this is the best piece of computer audio hardware you can buy right now.

Company **Creative**

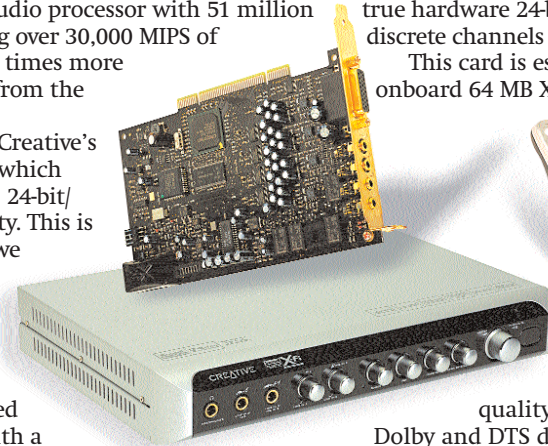
Price **Rs 27,990**

Phone **9321029204**

E-mail **india_getcreative@ctl.creative.com**

Web site **www.soundblaster.com**

Rating



Asus PW191 19-inch LCD

A Geek Magnet

The ASUS PW191 is an anti-glare TFT-LCD screen with a black piano-finish casing that will bowl you over. It incorporates a 90-degree pivot aluminium head-stand, and it supports both landscape and portrait views.

The PW191's WXGA screen supports a resolution of 1400 x 900 (16:10) at contrast ratio of 600:1. A response time of 8 ms supported by a good viewing angle of approximately 150 degrees makes this LCD monitor a good choice for gamers and movie buffs.

The elegant front panel encloses touch sensor buttons and twin speakers of 2 watts rms each. Headphone, audio and video input jacks are located at the back, just below the pivot. But there are two things we didn't like about the sensor buttons: first, they are unpredictable, and second, it's hard to locate the buttons in the dark if the monitor is off.

Kudos to the designers for putting a lot of thought into the design of the PW191—a good lifestyle product.

Company **ASUSTek Computer Inc.**

Price **Rs 29,000**

Phone **022-40058894/95/96/97**

E-mail **info_india@asus.com.tw**

Web site **http://in.asus.com**

Rating



ASUS EAX1800XT TOP

Gaming Nirvana For You

The ASUS EAX1800XT TOP is based on ATI's new-gun-in-town—the X1800XT chip. This Shader Model 3.0-compliant card brings a new degree of realism to games due to its support for HDR. It comes equipped with a core clocked at 700 MHz and 512 MB of DDR3 memory at 1.6 GHz—both of which are higher than the stock speeds.

The card is quite large, and occupies two slots on your motherboard. Its higher power requirements are taken care of by the bundled external power supply. The card is a remarkably silent performer.

The EAX1800XT proved its worth by scoring 10,330 and 4926 in 3DMark05 and 3DMark06 respectively—the best we have seen so far. Extreme performance was also noticeable in graphics-heavy games such as *Doom 3* and *Half-life 2* even when played at the highest graphics settings.

ASUS has bundled a force-feedback game controller as well as some good software, along with games such as *King Kong*. The ASUS EAX1800XT is a great performer, and not too expensive for hardcore gamers with a price tag of Rs 42,120.

Company **ASUSTek Computer Inc.**

Price **Rs 42,120**

Phone **022-40058894**

E-mail **info_india@asus.com.tw**

Web site **http://in.asus.com**

Rating

